BATTLE OF THE GUARANTEES

A RESURGENT CONGRESS UNDER CM SIDDARAMAIAH IS RELYING ON ITS WELFARE GUARANTEES TO NEUTRALISE PM NARENDRA MODI'S CHARISMA AND THE IMPACT OF HIS FLAGSHIP SCHEMES

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THE ELECTORAL LANDSCAPE IN KARNATAKA has been marked by a curious paradox since the turn of the century. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has been the biggest beneficiary of seats in parliamentary polls in the state since 2004, but has yet to win a state assembly election outright. At the same time, the Congress has come to power twice in Karnataka with a clear majority over these two decades, but has never gone beyond a single-digit seat tally in the four Lok Sabha polls held during these two long decades.

No doubt, then, that the BJP has the upper hand in Karnataka when it comes to parliamentary elections. But that, ironically, also puts a lot of pressure on the saffron formation in 2024 when it's crucial for it to maximise its gains from the southern state. This is because the BJP had set a record for itself in 2019 by pulling off a near-clean sweep—it won 25 of the 28 Lok Sabha seats and got the backing of a lone Independent, thereby reducing the Opposition to a paltry two seats. The BJP's quandary, therefore, this election: can it equal or better this feat?

The party's manoeuvres in this direction began in November when it revamped its state unit and handed B.Y. Vijayendra, son of Lingayat strongman and former chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa, its reins as president. Essentially, this was the BJP's attempt at course correction after it replaced Yediyurappa with Basavaraj Bommai in July 2021, which became one of the factors in its crushing defeat in the May 2023 assembly polls. The Congress was able to win over key